

Frequency, Chance, Likelihood, Probability, and Confidence

A Quick-Reference Guide

Chance, likelihood, probability			Frequency	
	<i>Chance</i>	<i>Term</i>	<i>Chance</i>	<i>Term</i>
1	100:100	<u>will</u> verb ; <u>definitely will</u> verb [note sarcastic variations]	100:100	always (Sarcasm: never)
2	85-100:100	<u>Most likely will</u> verb, will most likely verb, will likely verb,	95-100:100	almost always, just about always, often, very often, frequently, almost every X
3	50-100: 100	probably will verb; <u>chances are</u> , there is a good chance that, the odds are, the odds are in favor of; will verb.	[more than 50%]	usually, normally, most of the time, typically, generally, ordinarily, regularly, (on) most days,
4	15-85:100	could verb; could be going; might verb; could possibly verb; maybe will verb,	40-100: 100	usually, often, normally, commonly, periodically, always (casual),
5	1-60: 100	<u>may</u> verb;	15-85:100	sometimes, occasionally (usually less than 50% but not always)
6	1-49: 100	<u>perhaps</u> verb ; probably won't verb,	1-30:100	rarely, seldom, sometimes, occasionally, from time to time, hardly ever,
7	1-30:100	it is <u>doubtful</u> that I will verb; There is <u>a (small) chance</u> that it will verb.		
8	1-10:100	it is <u>unlikely</u> that ; Not likely; There is <u>a slim chance</u> that verb.	1-10:100	almost never, very rarely, quite seldom, don't often, don't normally, just about never
9	0:100	<u>won't</u> verb; <u>will not</u> verb [note sarcastic variations]	0:100	never (sarcasm: always)

Note: A lot of the meaning has to do with how it is used, in particular how it is said.

e.g. "all the time"

<i>Uncertainty,</i>	<i>Asking about probability:</i>	<i>Modifying Words:</i>	<i>Asking about Frequency:</i>	<i>Confidence: can, will, might, could, should, may, ought to,</i>	<i>Rate vs. Chance</i>	<i>Context Interpretation Heuristic:</i>
<i>Vagueness, Possible Disagreement:</i> (Yes) - certainly, undoubtedly, of course - probably - possibly - could be - Maybe - doubtful - unlikely - probably not - Not likely (no)	(e.g. "he can cook well") Do you think _? Can he probably ____? How likely is it that ____?	<u>ever</u>: do you ever <u>only</u>: only occasionally, only sometimes, only rarely <u>quite</u>: quite often <u>really</u>: really often <u>very</u>: very often most X (often, frequently) just about = almost: just about never <u>Not</u>: Not often /don't often, <u>don't always</u> <u>Don't normally</u>,	1. How <u>often</u> does she _____? 2. Does he <u>often</u> _____? 3. Does he _____ <u>often</u>? Does he ever/sometimes/often/commonly finish work before 5:30? How often/frequently does he finish work before 5:30? How often do you...? Do you often...? Does he go to Tokyo often? Do you _____ x? When do you _____? What time do you _____?	Studying English _____ make conversation with native speakers possible. will = 100% chance may = < 100% chance; maybe; 50/50 or less could = ≤ 50% ; low confidence might = polite form of could can = neutral Should/ought => 50%; high confidence	A higher probability of infection. A higher chance of infection. A higher likelihood of infection. A higher risk of infection. vs. A higher incidence of infection. A higher rate of infection. A higher frequency of infection	<u>A- How many contexts? + Technical vs. Casual</u> 1- Probability (% chance in the future) 2- Planning, desire, wish. 3- Should or should not: Good idea, bad idea 4- Common phrases with pre-set meanings 5. Duty/responsibility (should) 6. Ambiguity (certainty) [degree of] 7. Recommendation 8. Estimation, Prediction 9. Practicality, Convenience, feasibility <u>B -Probability</u> (most) 1st - will (100%) 2rd - ought to, should (50+%) 3rd - may (less than 100%) Maybe less than 50% "could" 4th - might less than 50% "could" (least) general/Neutral: Can (vs. can't) (could be anything, not zero) <u>C - "would" (Rule of thumb: Don't use the word "would")</u> I would get milk = I won't get milk. I would like to get some milk = Please give me milk. Would you please get us some milk. = I want milk.